

# RAKESH THORAT

## Strategic Leader – Talent Acquisition

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### EXECUTIVE PROFILE

India Talent Acquisition leader with more than 17 years of experience building, scaling, and transforming enterprise and technology hiring organizations for global companies including General Mills, UBS, and HSBC. Proven ability to enable large-scale India growth, architect TA operating models, and partner with India leadership teams, CHROs, HRBPs, and business heads to deliver workforce outcomes at scale.

### CORE EXPERTISE

TA Transformation | India Talent Strategy | Enterprise & Technology Hiring | Workforce Planning | Leadership Hiring | Campus & Early Career Strategy | Diversity & Inclusion | Stakeholder Management | Cost Optimization

### India & GCC Talent Acquisition Leadership Impact

- Led end-to-end Talent Acquisition transformation for India and GCC environments, spanning people, operating model, employer brand, and TA technology, to build a scalable, business-aligned hiring function.
- Trusted strategic partner to India Site Heads, Business Leaders, and Global HR leadership, translating multi-year growth strategies into predictable, sustainable India hiring outcomes.
- Built and developed high-performing TA leadership teams, establishing clear role charters, governance models, and performance management frameworks that positioned TA as a strategic business partner.
- Re-engineered end-to-end hiring processes to enable proactive workforce planning and demand prioritization, delivering 10–12% reduction in time-to-hire and improved quality of hire.
- Strengthened employer branding through targeted partnerships, campus and lateral hiring strategies, digital sourcing, and consistent EVP articulation, driving ~10% improvement in offer acceptance and candidate experience.
- Led ATS and TA tech stack transformation, delivering automation, compliance, real-time analytics, and visibility, while achieving 15–25% cost optimization through vendor rationalization and process efficiencies.
- Built and led 20–25 member TA organizations, designing robust hiring operating models and execution governance to balance speed, quality, and cost at scale.
- Known for reducing offer drop-offs, lowering agency dependency, and improving hiring ROI through stronger internal capability and disciplined governance.

## PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

### **TA DELIVERY LEAD | General Mills India | Jun 2025 – Present**

### **TA HEAD – INDIA | General Mills India | Jun 2022 – May 2025**

India Talent Acquisition leader responsible for building and scaling the end-to-end TA organization during a phase of rapid business growth. Owned India TA transformation, hiring strategy, leadership hiring, and stakeholder alignment across functions as change manager.

Executive leader accountable for enterprise-wide TA delivery, operating rhythm, and execution excellence. Partnered with global leadership, business heads, and HR leaders to design and execute the India GCC talent strategy—translating multi-year workforce plans into scalable hiring outcomes while balancing growth, cost, capability depth, leadership maturity, and strong governance across the India TA ecosystem.

- Own India Talent Acquisition strategy aligned to business growth plans
- Lead and develop a high-performing TA organization of 24 members
- Partner with India Site Head, Business Leaders, and HRBPs on workforce planning
- Delivered leadership hiring for Directors and Function Heads for the site
- Govern ATS (iCIMS), hiring processes, vendor ecosystem, and TA analytics
- Enabled 57% headcount growth (1,400 → 2,200 employees)
- Reduced offer decline rate from 32% to 21%
- Governed multi-crore India TA budget with board-level visibility, driving cost discipline, vendor rationalization & hiring ROI without compromising quality or speed.
- Represented the organization in India talent forums and ecosystem partnerships, strengthening employer brand visibility and long-term hiring pipelines.

### **ASSOCIATE DIRECTOR – TALENT ACQUISITION (TECHNOLOGY) | UBS India | Mar 2018 – Jun 2022**

Led Technology Talent Acquisition for UBS India during a hyper-growth phase, enabling large-scale expansion of the India Technology Center. Drove hiring strategy, recruiter capability building, cost optimization, and diversity outcomes in a highly competitive tech market.

- Led India Technology Talent Acquisition during hyper-growth phase
- Acted as India TA voice in leadership forums, shaping workforce decisions through predictive hiring data, market intelligence, and scenario planning.
- Managed a 23-member recruiting and sourcing organization
- Scaled India Technology Center from 1,000 to 7,000+ employees
- Reduced agency hiring costs from 28% to 7%
- Led campus hiring from tier 1 & 2 engineering colleges across India
- Achieved 30% female hiring via inclusive sourcing and hackathons

## **RECRUITMENT LEAD – TECHNOLOGY | HSBC Technology India | Sep 2008 – Feb 2018**

Progressed through increasing recruitment leadership responsibility while supporting large-scale growth of HSBC Technology India. Played a key role in building mature hiring processes, early adoption of ATS, and long-term graduate and diversity pipelines.

- Supported scale-up of HSBC Technology India from 7,000 to 15,000 employees
- Led full-cycle technology recruitment across Investment, Retail & Wealth Banking
- Partnered closely with Technology Heads, Delivery Leaders, and HRBPs to align hiring demand with delivery timelines and workforce plans.
- Managed recruitment vendors and agencies with a strong focus on cost control, quality, and delivery SLAs, laying the foundation for later cost-optimization models.
- Acted as the sole senior executive partner for HSBC Technology India's RPO time & motion study (2007), defining recruitment productivity metrics, role effort models, and cost baselines that informed the decision to transition large-scale hiring to an RPO model during rapid expansion.
- Built HSBC's Tier-1 campus hiring strategy in India as a scalable early-career talent pipeline; subsequently partnered with HSBC UK to replicate and operationalize the model, exporting India best practices to a global market
- Improved graduate diversity from 11% to 36% with end-to-end leading graduate hiring for technology
- Launched India–China–UK graduate exchange program

## **AWARDS & RECOGNITION**

- Engaging Leader Award – General Mills
- UBS Global Recruitment Award – Career Comeback Program
- Ally of the Year (LGBTQ+ Inclusion) – UBS
- HSBC "Rise" Award – 3 consecutive years

## **EDUCATION**

B.Sc. | Pune University (2005)